

Primary Source Reading 2: Justice as Each Part Doing Its Own Work

Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) From Plato's Republic, Book IV, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 11b: Justice in the Soul and the Rule of Reason

Before you read: Socrates has established that the soul has three parts. Now he asks what it would mean for a soul to be just. As you read, notice that his answer is not about following rules or avoiding specific bad acts — it is about the internal arrangement of the three parts themselves. Justice turns out to be a kind of order, and injustice a kind of civil war.

Each Part Doing Its Own Business

SOCRATES: No one will be less likely to commit adultery, or to dishonour his father and mother, or to fail in his religious duties.

GLAUCON: No one.

SOCRATES: And the reason is that each part of him is doing its own business, whether in ruling or being ruled?

GLAUCON: Exactly so.

SOCRATES: Are you satisfied then that the quality which makes such men and such states is justice, or do you hope to discover some other?

GLAUCON: Not I, indeed. (443b–d)

The Inward Man

SOCRATES: In reality justice was such as we were describing, being concerned however, not with the outward man, but with the inward, which is the true self and concernment of man: for the just man does not permit the several elements within him to interfere with one another, or any of them to do the work of others — he sets in order his own inner life, and is his own master and his own law, and at peace with himself; and when he has bound together the three principles within him, which may be compared to the higher, lower, and middle notes of the scale, and the intermediate intervals — when he has bound all these together, and is no longer many, but has become one entirely temperate and perfectly adjusted nature, then he proceeds to act... always thinking and calling that which preserves and co-operates with this harmonious condition, just and good action, and the knowledge which presides over it, wisdom. (443c–e)

Injustice as Civil War

SOCRATES: And now, injustice has to be considered.

GLAUCON: Clearly.

SOCRATES: Must not injustice be a strife which arises among the three principles — a meddlesomeness, and interference, and rising up of a part of the soul against the whole, an assertion of unlawful authority, which is made by a rebellious subject against a true prince, of whom he is the natural vassal — what is all this confusion and delusion but injustice, and intemperance and cowardice and ignorance, and every form of vice?

GLAUCON: Exactly so. (444b)

After you read: Notice that Socrates never defines justice by listing forbidden acts. Instead, he defines it structurally: justice is an internal arrangement, and the good behavior (keeping promises, honoring parents, and so on) simply follows from that arrangement being right. Injustice, correspondingly, is not first a list of bad deeds — it is a civil war inside the soul, one part usurping the authority of another. As you move into the lesson, ask yourself which parts of Socrates's musical image — the higher, lower, and middle notes bound into one harmonious whole — are doing the real philosophical work, and which are just a memorable way of putting it.